I'd lost that edge. I played out certain scenarios in my mind – obviously finishing with a home Ashes series in 2019 would have been ideal – but getting out for 13 and 0, to a couple of good deliveries, in the first Test against India at Edgbaston that summer of 2018 proved to be a persuasive reality check. My mind was finally made up during the third Test at Trent Bridge.

This wasn't submission to the self-doubt that inevitably creeps in during a run of low scores; it was the liberation of sudden clarity that there was only one solution to the problem. I arrived back at the team hotel on the third evening of the match, when I was 9 not out overnight, fully intending to tell Alice I was in my last series. She was heavily pregnant with our son Jack, and to wind down, with the girls asleep next door, we watched the *Inbetweeners* movie in bed.

I fall asleep to the TV series on tour all the time. It has a comforting familiarity; I know all the words, and I'm usually out like a light before the introductory music ends. I've only watched the movie occasionally; that night we laughed out loud at the adolescent antics. I knew I had to tell her, but it seemed wrong to darken the mood.

Instead, I ignored the ICC anti-corruption code (belated apologies, chaps) and didn't hand my phone in when I reported to the ground the next morning. I texted Alice: 'Are you OK? I've got to tell you this. The end of this series is going to be my last game for England.' I saw the two blue ticks on WhatsApp, which signalled that she had read it, and felt a sudden nervousness as the word 'typing' appeared on screen.

I was thinking, 'Please don't fight it,' and praying for her acceptance. She had been a constant source of strength when I'd struggled with the complexities of captaincy, and the isolation of life on a difficult tour. We'd had a couple of long telephone conversations from Australia that winter, and she was attuned to my tentative cries for help. It seemed to take for ever for her to reply, but when she did so, she needed only two words.

'I know …'

Relief accompanied the realization that my inner struggle must have been blatantly obvious. Alice is, after all, the person who knows me better than anyone. I found a quiet anteroom in the changing area and made a call: 'I just can't keep going,' I told her. 'I've lost what makes me different from everyone else and I want to go out with my head held high.'